Towards a new relationship

The asymmetry that marked cultural relations was supplanted by a perhaps more reciprocal relationship in the exchange of goods – 'perhaps' because we have no records of the volume of trade. Tansen Sen in his wonderful synoptic history of India–China relations from ancient to modern times presents a vivid picture of the material economy that replaced the spiritual economy. After the tenth century, an array of goods, beyond Buddhist relics and paraphernalia, went from India to China: exotic and other animals (including horses from Arabia), plants and plant products, spices and foods, drugs and herbs, precious and semi-precious stones, gold and silver objects, pearls, ivory products, incense, textiles especially cotton, and even slaves. In return, Chinese rulers sent silk and, in one case, slaves, musk, robes, jewels, quivers, and swords. They also granted traders the right to sell their wares in China and offered tax exemptions. Chinese traders sold silk and other textiles, spices, and porcelain.[9]

Sen reminds us that Sanskrit texts of the pre-Buddhist period had contained references to products that are suffixed by the word 'cina' including *cinani* (peaches), *cinasi* (hides), *cinarajaputra* (pears), and *cinaka* (camphor) and of course *cinamsuka* or *cinapatta* (silk). However, this did not imply that the two societies knew a great deal about each other: most of the products that came from China were through intermediaries in Central Asia.[10] During the period of intense spiritual encounter, Buddhist paraphernalia were the mainstay of material flows. Later, diplomatic gifts were part of the flow. Later still, tributes to China from maritime polities in the Indic region including Ceylon dominated material exchange.

Indian tributes to China

These tributes did not necessarily signify subordination, though Song China and Yuan China under Kublai Khan tried to control maritime trade in the Indian Ocean – and Kublai Khan threatened and then sent punitive